

Oral communication has an ancient foundation; its roots go back to the time of the Greeks and Romans—and earlier.

In the ancient world, writers such as Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian—familiar to many people—were some of the Greek and Roman practitioners of the art of rhetoric or persuasion. Its roots are deep. Its heritage is oral.

Our statement suggests that orally moving a message from sender to receiver is not new. Throughout each day, in your personal life and in the workplace, you orally communicate with customers, colleagues, associates, supervisors, employees, employers, and others.

This chapter introduces you to successful strategies needed to be effective in oral communication:

- Strategies for improving oral presentations
- Strategies for reducing stage-fright
- Strategies for improving listening

In a sense this chapter is macro, providing an overview of oral communication, rather than micro. Later chapters are more specific: informative and persuasive speaking, interpersonal communication, and business and group settings. We begin with viewing basic strategies.

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING ORAL PRESENTATIONS *is public speaking*

During your career in the business world, you will give various kinds of oral presentations. Indeed, how your capabilities are measured will initially occur on your oral words. You need a strategy.

Oral presentations need a strategy: To reflect favorably upon you.

This section takes you through the steps needed to be effective in oral communication:

- Steps for preparing effective oral presentations
- Kinds of oral presentations
- Ways of delivering the oral message
- Strategies for using an effective oral delivery
- Strategies for effective nonverbal delivery

Steps for Preparing Effective Oral Presentations

Seven steps are essential for successful oral statements, short or long. The up-front preparation you do, the more confidence you will have before

1. Determine the purpose.
2. Analyze the audience and occasion.
3. Select the main ideas for the message.
4. Research the topic.
5. Organize the data and write the draft.
6. Create visual aids.
7. Rehearse the talk.

Communication Probe

A recent study sought to determine which modes of communication were used during a business day. Out of the eight modes frequently cited, oral communication dominated, with face-to-face communication the most common (81.4% U.S.; 77.5% Asian; and 94.4% Chinese) and use of the telephone next (81.4% U.S.; 90.0% Asian; and 87.6% Chinese). The following table suggests that within three cultures—even where written communication is extensively used—businesspersons still prefer to interact on the personal, oral level. It will be interesting to see what occurs over the years if more intensive use of electronic communication decreases the need for interpersonal contact.

Modes of communication used by selected U.S. executives and Asian and Chinese managers

Modes	U.S. Executives*	Asian Managers†	Chinese Managers
Face to face	81.4%	77.5%	94.4%
Telephone	81.4	90.0	87.6
Written	69.9	55.0	87.1
Mail	NA‡	NA	69.0
Teleconference	12.9	5.0	11.5
Telex	NA	NA	15.6
Fax	NA	NA	9.5
Computers	10.7	30.0	20.5

* Executives are defined as chief executive officers, presidents, and vice presidents.

† Not available in the U.S. Executive and Asian Manager database.

‡ Includes Singapore, Malaysia, and Hong Kong managers.

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Liu, J. (1991). Communication through foreign languages: An economic force in Chinese enterprises. *Journal of Asian Pacific Communication*, 2(1) 45-67.

Determine the Purpose

We communicate to produce a result. We wish something to occur as a result of our words. On the macro level these overall goals are: to inform, to persuade, to entertain.

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Basic types of oral communication are found in speaking, informing, persuading, and entertaining.

1. **To Inform or Instruct.** Here your core goal is to clarify, secure understanding, explain a process. Your teacher, most often, is making a speech to inform. So are your authors as we write about the process of oral communication. In brief, at the conclusion of your message you hope listeners have a better comprehension of an issue, an idea, a process, a procedure.

2. **To Persuade.** Gaining willing acceptance of an idea is core to persuasion. Note that the key word here is *willing*. Your goal is that after you have finished your presentation, listeners will accept your proposal, your claim, your thesis.

you hope they will do as you ask them to do. Advertisements also have a persuasive result. But their tools of persuasion may include the oral plus many kinds of persuasive devices.

3. To Entertain. This speaking genre may include not only humorous remarks you will make—of which there will probably be few—but also the serious ceremonial, introductory, or stimulating statements. Social occasions such as promotion parties, retirement, or anniversaries are characteristic of this speaking.

Analyze the Audience and Occasion

Whether one writes or speaks, the message must be adapted to the audience. If your talk is within your organization, you will have some idea about who many people will be in the audience.

Less information is available when speaking to outside groups. The only out-information such as the size of the group, age range, interests, goals, and other tidbits which could be incorporated into your remarks is that information may be obtained from the person who asked you to speak or from other members of the group. If all audience members have the same participation, such as purchasing agents or computer salespersons, you can use technical expressions and illustrations.

Select the Main Ideas for the Message

Selecting your main theme or your core ideas should be done first. Then adding additional information will be in support of those core ideas. Your first core ideas may be disorganized, haphazard, which is fine. Later you can select those ideas that are workable and offer a unified theme. Some speakers, with filling a complete page with single words or incomplete sentences, onto this list they impose a form of organization. Do not rush this stage of organization; do not presume this initial structure will be your final version.

Research the Topic

It is obvious that you will not possess all information relating to your theme. Thus, as in writing, you need to collect facts, data, information. Your search may cause you to drop some of your initial ideas and add new ones. You have only to read newspaper accounts of the President's speech to realize that it is still under revision until the last moment. New facts, new views are constantly appearing.

Organize the Data and Write the Draft

Assume that you have completed gathering your information. Then it is time to force some order on your information, usually in the form of an initial outline.

■ Communication Probe

Research on communication issues was fervent during the 1970s. Two such studies during that period suggest that the credibility of the speaker is a major predictor of success in persuasion. On the other hand if a speaker feels he or she is lacking in credibility as perceived by an audience, he or she can refer to experiences with the topic. Or, the speaker can connect him or herself with others who are competent on the topic. Therefore, one conclusion is to search out evidence that supports your message in a credible, hopefully uncontested manner.

Lashbrook, V. (1971). Source credibility: A summary of experimental research. Paper presented at the Speech Communication Association convention, San Francisco; McCroskey, J. C. (1969). A summary of experimental research on the effects of evidence in persuasive communication. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 55, 169-176.

you do this, remember that a good speech has three parts: an introduction, a body (or text, discussion), and a conclusion or summary.

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to recall the major
of an introduc-
aim, layout.

1. Introduction. Traditionally an introduction seeks to do several things: Get attention, include an aim or purpose, and lay out the direction of the speech. Think of these three elements as a PAL:

- | | |
|--------|---|
| Porch | Your opening remarks. It is your throat-clearing statement, your preamble, your preface, your greeting. Additionally you may begin with a quotation, a question, a startling statement, a reference to the occasion, a reference to the past, a humorous story. Use these choices to get started. |
| Aim | Your purpose. Why you are giving the talk. Here you clearly state the aim for your remarks; you make clear your intent. |
| Layout | Your agenda. Cicero long ago suggested such a "layout" was the division of one's remarks. Telling the audience your main parts, often by number, gives them a precise understanding of the major points you will cover; it's the roadmap for what follows. |

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main pur-
sentation.

2. Body (Text, Discussion). Some people refer to the heart of the message as the text or discussion. Here you include evidence data for your central theme; here you organize the supports for your central purpose. Organizing the body of the talk is similar to developing the text or discussion of a major paper. However, in speaking there is often a time constraint; such a constraint demands that most talks be limited to two or three main points.

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3. Summary or Conclusion. A summary reminds the audience of the main ideas covered in the body of the talk, whereas a conclusion draws inferences

Conclusion

Cicero

Dose

from the data. Regardless of your intent, there must be an ending or to your remarks.

Create Visual Aids

Some presentations do not require visuals. It would be odd to include a head of the major dates in the career of a retiree. On the other hand, it would be odd not to include a visual when speaking about the structure of an organization. But most important is answering this question: Would a visual add standing and support of your message? A discussion of different kinds of visual aids is included in Appendix A.

Rehearse the Talk

Two purposes underlie rehearsals: You will become more comfortable with the material and you can still revise where necessary. When rehearsing, deliver your talk out loud.

How many times should you rehearse? Three times is about the right number. Nevertheless, a company president presenting a holiday greeting rehearsed four times; a vice president before a congressional committee went through the talk three times; a President of the United States rehearsed once. The decision is up to you.

Keep in mind the following issues:

- Always imagine the audience in front of you.
- Use transitional phrases and sentences to show your listeners the relationships between sections of your report. Avoid long sentences and unusual words.
- Take each of the main points one at a time and learn to present its supporting material as a unit.
- Include the visual aids you'll use—and in the margin, note where each aid should be used.
- Anticipate questions from the audience. Jot them on paper and prepare thoughtful answers.
- Stop at the allotted time. Then cut and revise the speech accordingly until you can deliver it within the time limit, allowing also for a question-and-answer period.

Ask questions from audience =>

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Oral Presentations

Basically, all oral communication lies between informative speaking on one end and persuasion at the other end. For most purposes the two are therefore some variation of inform, persuade, or entertain. Additionally, you could add such variations as motivate, inspire, and eulogize. But these are all relatives of the three basic forms, discussed earlier in this chapter.

Short talks may range from 1 to 10 minutes in length. You may introduce someone, present an award to a retiree, give a briefing to visitors, or offer an opening statement in a group meeting. You could also represent the company outside your office: accepting an award, showing

Checklist 14.1 Preparing Effective Oral Messages

1. Know the precise purpose of your presentation: Will you inform, persuade, or entertain?
2. Identify your audience and the situation. What are their approximate ages, their occupations, their interests, their biases, their reasons for being present?
3. Select the main ideas, the core concepts you wish to discuss.
4. Research your topic thoroughly.
5. Organize your information and prepare a first draft.
6. Create some visual aids, if necessary (Appendix A).
7. Rehearse your talk at least three times.

for the presentation,
the risk of losing
the audience's attention.

port for a local cause, offering greetings at a community banquet. And so on and on.

Longer statements may vary from 10 minutes to 1 hour. It is not unusual in Asia, for instance, to have speeches 2 hours long. But with the increasing emphasis on brevity, some corporations limit statements to 20 or 30 minutes, knowing that attention spans decrease the longer the statement.

Delivering the Oral Message types

You have four options for speaking: extemporaneous, reading, memorization, and impromptu delivery.

1. Extemporaneous *Speak without rehearsing*

This method—most preferred by audience and speakers—allows a speaker to use notes or an outline. He or she usually may use 3 by 5-inch cards or a full sheet of paper as notes for the remarks.

Use this method whenever possible: It allows more eye contact with an audience, permits you to establish rapport, and enables you to move with ease.

2. Reading/manuscript

Major political figures and others who do not want to make a mistake read a manuscript. If they will be filmed or have their statement appear on the evening news, ad-libbing could lead to problems. A familiar story runs like this. A speaker once read his remarks and got this reaction from a listener: "I didn't like your reading your speech; I didn't think you read it well; and I didn't think what you read was worth reading!"

Today speakers on television often "read" from a teleprompter, a device allowing them to read their words directly from a script passing in front of the camera lens. Recent presidents of the United States have favored this method.

When constructing a manuscript for reading, some speakers use a format similar to a TV script, leaving a left margin of about one-third of the page. That wide margin is for pronunciation aids or suggestions as to where to look at the audience.

3. Memorization

Few speakers today memorize complete speeches. Nor should they. The first few words of a statement can be memorized, but the time needed for a long speech is prohibitive.

4. Impromptu *Without Reading*

Many of us are called upon at the last moment to offer comments. We speak "off the cuff," without preparation, without a forewarning that we are speaking impromptu.

How can you prepare? Winston Churchill, the energetic British prime minister during the Second World War, "rehearsed" his impromptu remarks. Later, in the House of Commons, he gave the impression that his remarks were spur of the moment. A vice president doodled through a discussion. He was also jotting down notes for later use in his "impromptu" remarks.

Strategies for an Effective Oral Delivery

our personal signature
our voice: varying
pitch, and volume
more interest and

As writing has its criteria to move ideas clearly across a page, so too does speaking in an oral situation. In addition to completing the seven steps for writing an oral message and choosing the methods of delivering it, you need to focus on decreasing stage fright and the desirable elements of oral and nonverbal delivery.

Your voice is your trademark: it is that part of yourself that adds the personal element to your words. Writing does not have that immediacy because words are static on a page. You can give extra life to your delivery in five traditional ways.

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One of your authors, early on, investigated this hypothesis: Does the mode of presentation—that is, extemporaneous or manuscript delivery—affect an audience's recall of information? Results suggest that the mode of communication employed makes no difference: Audiences recall information about equally well when speakers use either method. However, audiences—beyond question—desired the extemporaneous mode of delivery. They simply liked it more. Fortunately, in the business world most presentations are of the extemporaneous type.

Hildebrandt H. W., & Stevens, W. (1963). Manuscript and extemporaneous delivery: communicating information. *Speech Monographs*, 30, 369-382.

1. Pitch

At its simplest level *pitch* is the *highness or lowness of your voice*. In speaking, this pitch should be varied. Traditional problems in using pitch are *monotone*, *high or low voice*, and *same word value*.

Monotone: "He's a monotone" is no compliment. This critical statement implies that the speaker has little or no variation in pitch. An oscilloscope could draw a rather flat line.

High or Low Voice: Often monotones are voices that rarely rise out of a lower register. On the other hand, excited people frequent the upper ranges.

Same Word Value. In writing we emphasize a word visually by underlining it, marking it boldface, or using italics. When each word in speaking, regardless of its importance in a thought group, is the same, the speaker does not distinguish with vocal stress between important and unimportant words. Cantonese, for instance, is an accented language. Much pitch variation occurs.

The above problems are decreased through pitch changes, through glides—from a higher to a lower level, abruptly. Say this sentence: "Mary, don't do that!" On which word did you raise your voice? Here are the possibilities:

1. Mary, don't do that!

2. Mary, don't do that!

3. Mary, don't do that!

4. Mary, don't do that!

When emphasizing an entire sentence, usually the strong declarative thoughts end with a downward pitch change, giving the feeling of finality, of determination. A rising inflection is more appropriate to asking questions or suggesting indecision.

2. Rate

Take a guess: How many words do you use per minute as you speak? Most communication experts suggest the range for public speakers lies between 80 to 160 words per minute. In more casual conversation some people may range from 50 to 250 words per minute.

What the above statement suggests is that the rate of speech varies from individual to individual. A speaker may be considered dull if he or she is slow or unvarying, even though the speaker's content may be superior. Conversely, the fast speaker also causes discomfort. We hope the rapid-fire speaker will slow down in order for us to digest the thoughts.

A key word related to rate is *pause*. We call pauses between major thought groups "oral white space," similar to the white space between paragraphs in a written document. As in writing, a pause in speaking lets your receiver reflect on the message and helps break the flow of thought. A pause lets you, the speaker, collect your thoughts, take time to move to a visual, or rest your voice.

3. Volume

Unless you as a speaker are heard, many of your words will be lost. It takes courage for a listener to stand at the rear of a room and shout "Speak up." Volume is the loudness or softness of your voice. How do you improve it?

Contrast in Emphasis. Contrast in emphasis involves using a louder volume on certain words, certain ideas, certain parts of your talk, even syllables. For instance, how would you orally deliver the following statement?

And with that we conclude our remarks. Perhaps I look forward to working with you and the other members of your project team. I can't forget that at one time I was asked to join your firm. On the other side, offering a proposal that you'll accept. Regardless of your final decision, we wish you to know that we enjoyed this work with you.

When in doubt as to your volume level, ask a colleague about her or his impressions from the back or side of a room.

In the above instance—heard by one of the authors—the speaker raised his voice and made the statement a moving personal appeal at the conclusion of a rigorous 3-hour team presentation.

Controlled Breathing. Too frequently speakers breathe in shallow bursts—as does a singer—have lungs filled with air in order to produce a high pressure level to propel the air forcefully past your vocal folds. Breathe deep, slow, deep breathing prior to speaking helps to decrease stage fright symptoms.

Certainly you must adapt your volume level to the size of the audience and the room. Speaking to 100 people in a room without an amplification system surely demand more volume than in a small room of 5 people.

One's voice is hard to describe; we often turn to metaphors to describe voice quality.

4. Vocal Quality

Before reading the next several lines, pause and see how many words you can think of that describe the human voice. Did you choose any of the following: husky, throaty, deep, loud, vibrant, dynamic, mellow, moving, warm, harsh, shrill, effeminate, masculine, gentle, squeaky, muffled, falsetto, hissing, clear, ringing, effortless, secure, flexible, serene, pliable, vibrant, furry rug? Many of the preceding are metaphors, implying a comparison of your voice with another known quantity. Regardless of your voice's quality, it is definable something that distinguishes your voice from others.

There is some debate about whether anything can be done about voice quality. Your mouth, tongue, lips, teeth, vocal folds, sinuses, hard palate, and nose all affect that quality. If you are unhappy with your voice, consult a competent speech therapist for professional help. Some experts also recommend relaxing the throat, thereby allowing an unrestricted sound to enter the chambers of the mouth, throat, and nasal cavities.

5. Pronunciation

We more easily forgive pronunciation errors in foreign speakers than in native speakers. You are expected to be correct in the business world. In the

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A lighthearted spoof—quite serious, really—of jargon and its consequences in the business world recently appeared. The author's observation is that consultants entering a company to improve communication come loaded with their own vocabularies, their own font of words. Thus with some difficulty the company must learn about *empowerment*, *paradigms*, *vision congruencies*, *short-term disabilities*, *cultural interventions*, and a host of others. Soon, however, the company is mouthing these same terms, or in the author's terms "psychobabble." Undemeath the satire the message is clear: Do not neglect the simplicity of the English language; do not give up clarity for jargon.

Theibert, T. (1994, August 1). Eschew that paradigm! Drop the jargon. *Wall Street Journal*, 18A.

consciously react negatively when any word is mispronounced—relative to our concept of how it should be pronounced. (Danger: we may be wrong, the speaker right.)

Additional pronunciation problems need to be mentioned.

onload language

Jargon. Within your organization you will learn jargon pronunciations, often for abbreviations. Thus *cam* used within one group will mean "contract audit manual," but to outsiders could mean a part that forces a roller to move. A danger clearly lies in using these in-group pronunciations outside your group, with inevitable quizzical nonverbal reactions from your listeners.

Varied Regional Accents. For many words, southern pronunciation and accents, for example, differ from those in Chicago or Boston. For most of these words, however, there is a common standard throughout the states, as there must be for us to understand quickly.

Added or Omitted Sounds. Speakers should, of course, be careful not to add such sounds as *uh*, *hm*, *y'know*, *er*, *OK* between words or sentences. If one has many of these interjections (one speaker had 24, another 42, another 147), they break up the flow of words for the listener. The result is similar to the negative impression that writing errors leave with a reader. Some speakers literally don't hear their interjections until they hear them played back on a videotape.

Other bad habits of adding and omitting may also affect pronunciation. In the following examples, the preferred pronunciation is second:

Adding

idear	idea
athalete	athlete
arthuritis	arthritis
hunerd	hundred

Omitting

gonna	going to
watcha say	what did you say
meetn	meeting
dija	did you

Variety

All the following suggestions move on one main assumption: variety and enthusiasm in each of the vocal characteristics.

1. Try repeating thought groups in your speech in different ways: Which way sounds more effective through varying pitch (highness/lowness of the voice); rate (fastness/slowness of speech); loudness/softness.
2. Think of adding oral white space: Insert silence (pauses) between points of your talk.
3. Be sure you have the correct pronunciation of words. This is most appropriate for persons using English as a second language. In doubt, ask a native speaker or check the dictionary for the pronunciation.

Suggestions for improving pronunciation are:

Listen to the Educated and Cultured People of Your Community. Usually assume that their standard is correct and acceptable for the country. A respected businessperson's speech is also a good guide.

Consult a Recent Dictionary. More options on pronunciations included in recent editions. When in doubt, get a consensus from members or your instructors.

Strategies for an Effective Nonverbal Delivery

How much do you nonverbally communicate about yourself? How close do you stand to someone in polite conversation? How do you dress your attire when speaking? These are questions often raised when discussing nonverbal communication. Your posture, movement, gesture, facial expression, and attire all convey external nonverbal cues. Many nonverbal cues are discussed in Chapter 3.

1. Posture

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Many of you have seen the film *Patton*, in which the actor George C. Scott plays the role of General Patton. In one scene Scott delivers a ringing statement: He delivers it erect, straight, and unbending. The entire scene suggests confidence, rapport with his audience of soldiers. One senses the confidence of the speaker.

Thus, when you stand straight and balance your weight on both feet, you give the impression of complete control, of poise. Your outward appearance reflects your inner mood.

■ Communication Probe

Although extensive communication research was conducted in the sixties and seventies, Professor Roger D. Masters has continued that investigation specifically as it applies to political leaders. But some of his conclusions have applicability beyond the political arena. In fact, all audiences dislike speakers who exhibit fear: looking down, hesitating, jerky in movement, or seeming to freeze. People react positively when candidates smile warmly, tilt their head, and establish eye contact with their audience. "If you think about it," he says, "politics is about getting people to look at you. Our studies show that effective leaders are attention-binding."

McDonald, K. (1996, January 5). The body language of leadership. *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, A6-A9; Masters, R. (1993). *Beyond relativism: Science and human values*. Hanover, NH: University Press of New England; Masters, R. (1999). *The nature of politics*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.

Conversely, when draped over a podium with your shoulders sagging, you give the feeling of depression, of lack of control. However, a casual posture may also be adapted to the audience. When speaking to a business conference of, say, 10 people, you might sit on the edge of a table or even address them from a chair. Certainly a formal talk to 200 people would demand more formality in posture.

Women should be especially concerned about posture, sometimes choosing shorter-heeled shoes when speaking. Too high a heel causes some female speakers to rock from side to side. Choose a comfortable set of shoes to avoid conveying a negative, ill-at-ease impression.

2. Movement

Taking a few steps during a presentation helps hold attention, as does any moving object. There are times, however, when a lecturer precludes extensive movement other than short steps to its side. Yet, move if possible, for the following reasons:

Move to Hold Attention. At large sessions, lecterns restrict your movement. In business meetings the audience may be smaller, thus permitting you to stand behind a desk or table. Move more often from side to side rather than back and forth. But do not move continuously, like a caged lion!

Move to Get Rid of Nervousness. A way of decreasing stage fright is to move about, especially in the beginning of your talk. Even the manner in which you approach the lectern tells something about you nonverbally. Are you slow and plodding, or do you move with assurance, determination, enthusiasm? The latter approach gives a confident feeling while decreasing some of your initial nervousness.

Move to Suggest Transitions. Cues for transitions in writing include headings, words, and numerical hints such as (1), (2), (3) or (a), (b), (c). In your talk you

One of the earliest researchers into nonverbal communication (Mehrabian, 1971) suggested that words alone do not carry meaning in communication. He argued that no more than 30 to 35 percent of meaning is carried by words. Nonverbal communication adds, subtracts, and modifies the messages we send. Nonverbal symbols, in conjunction with verbal symbols, say much about who we are, how we feel, and even how we think about others. Hence, the oral communication context involves both verbal and nonverbal symbols, each hopefully getting listeners to understand and do what we wish them to do. Sending the right symbols depends on knowing the audience's receptivity to those symbols.

Birdwhistle, R. (1970). *Kinesics and context*. Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press; Knapp, M. L. (1990). Nonverbal communication. In G. L. Dunbar & J. Terhune (Eds.), *Human communication: Theory and Research* (pp. 50-60). CA: Wadsworth.

voice, varying help to hold of an audi-

visually supplement the oral words of transition by physically moving in a direction shift. The audience follows you more easily.

Move to Increase Emphasis. In writing we use exclamation points for emphatic statements. In speaking, a movement toward the audience, aided by a gesture, can imply you are stressing a point. Emphasis movement suggests idea importance and holds group attention.

3. Gestures *During the Talk movement of your body*

At a simplistic level any movement of the hands, arms, head, and face is termed *gestures*. At a more micro level there is an entire science of movements called *kinesics*; of which gestures are a part:

Emblems. Behavior that has a direct verbal counterpart such as the hand signal for hitchhiking; the arm wave for hello or goodbye.

Illustrators. Here belong the gestures, usually the arm used to describe, or the finger pointing to emphasize a point. As emblems have a verbal counterpart, illustrators do not.

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Affect Displays. Speakers may use any of the primary emotions via facial expression: happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, disgust, and interest.

Regulators. Speakers use body movements of their audience to respond to their message. Thus listeners may nod their heads, maintain eye contact, shift their postures, incline their heads to hear better.

Adaptors. These are often the unintentional movements to a physical or emotional state: scratching a nose, twisting a pencil, smoothing one's hair.

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nacceptable in

Hand and arm gestures are used for several reasons:

To Emphasize. For example, the clenched fist emphasizes a point by either hitting the palm of the hand or shaking it upright before an audience.

To Point. The index finger calls attention, indicating either locations or directions.

To Reject. A sample phrase accompanying this gesture would be "I can't believe the actions of our competitors." Here the hand may go to the side in an act of rejection.

To Describe. Clearly, though your hands cannot give the precise picture of the idea or thing you are speaking about, even an approximation of size is worthwhile.

Finally, some suggestions regarding gestures are in order:

Vary Gestures. Using the same action repetitiously is boring to the audience and suggests lack of creativity on your part.

Avoid Continuous Gestures. Visually the audience needs a rest from the speaker's frequent gestures. Overuse can weaken the emphasis.

Watch Timing. The gesture should accompany the oral thought, not precede or follow it.

Adapt Gestures. Seated at a table is not the time for broad, all-inclusive gestures. On the other hand, a large audience would not see a small gesture. Adapt to the size of the group.

4. Facial Expressions

Earlier we suggested that one's facial expressions could convey primary gestures. Thus a smile or a laugh suggests that your topic interests you. A frown or

Communication Probe

Two tests over the years (Rosenthal, 1979, and Buck, 1984) have attempted to answer this question: Which gender is most perceptive in sending and receiving nonverbal messages? Rosenthal's Profile of Nonverbal Sensitivity (PONS) test and Buck's Communication of Affect-Receiving Ability Test (CARAT) lead to some interesting conclusions. Through viewing slides and film, with emphasis on the face, the body, and the voice, women seem to do better in sending and receiving nonverbal messages.

Rosenthal, R. (ed.). (1979). *Skill in nonverbal communication. Individual differences*. Cambridge, MA: Oelgeschlager, Gunn, & Haini Hall. J. A. (1984). *Nonverbal sex differences: Communication accuracy and expressive style*. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Checklist 14.3 Enhancing Your Nonverbal Communication

1. Stand erect. It is better to err on the side of more formality than nervousness in speaking.
2. Move! To hold attention, to get rid of nervousness, to suggest to increase emphasis.
3. Gestures add emphasis to your oral words. Use them to emphasize to suggest rejection of an idea, to describe size. Using your hands to hold attention.
4. Facial expressions suggest enthusiasm for your topic. A more interesting face. Look at the audience. Give them the feeling of interest in them and your topic.
5. Your attire is determined by the culture of your group. When more formal than informal.

glare may convey nonverbal impressions that you are worried, angry, ill at ease. You must not only feel but show interest in your ideas, important.

Facial expression includes eye contact. Speakers who bury their heads or who speak to the screen behind them lose a sense of connection with the audience. Eye contact with your listeners suggests respect, adding to a favorable impression of you as a speaker.

5. Appearance

Western attire is accepted throughout the world. Conversely, western businesspersons must recognize that other nations may have different dress codes.

Local newspapers often include questions about and answers to what you look and what affect listeners. Thus some companies are more casual in dress, others more formal. Learning the company culture includes learning its dress code.

Most western companies encourage males to wear the traditional suit and tie and females to wear a white blouse with a dark skirt and those "rules" are consistently changing. Terms as *smart casual* or *business casual* are symbols for appearance; it is important that you know what the rules are in your particular environment.

STRATEGIES FOR REDUCING STAGE FRIGHT

Being at ease, or simply giving the impression of being at ease, is what most people want. Few people can approach an audience without some feeling of comfort. In traditional rankings, speaking before an audience is not a fearful thing some people do.

Pick up any newspaper, read what persons have to say about handling a performance in front of people. Many resist and fear the public arena. Strained and avoided public performances for years out of stage

■ Communication Probe

Because speech anxiety is so widespread, numerous studies and approaches to meeting that anxiety have appeared over the years. Without getting into extensive detail, those anxiety-reducing techniques involved skills based on cognitive and affective approaches. A study that combined all three methods resulted in some interesting conclusions. Performance visualization is effective in reducing communication anxiety. Relaxation techniques were encouraged and imagining ability (reading a script of a successful speech and viewing a speech) was the type of performance visualization employed. "People who have the ability to imagine situations vividly receive more benefit from performance visualization than do others."

Ayers, J., Hopf, T., & Ayers, D. M. (1984). An examination of whether imagining ability enhances the effectiveness of an intervention designed to reduce speech anxiety. *Communication Education*, 40, 252-258.

Cliburn said, "Those who know me best know that when I walk out on a stage, I'm nervous, always nervous"; Luciano Pavarotti, the superb tenor, said, "I would not want even an enemy to suffer those terrible moments"; Steve Carlton, a recent inductee into the Baseball Hall of Fame, put it this way: "This is a wonderful thing... once the speech is over." And the list of similar comments is endless.

Signs of Discomfort

Signs of discomfort are universally experienced: The heart rate increases, blood pressure and body temperature rise, and some say their mouths feel dry. Look carefully at each of the preceding: All are internal, none are visible to the audience. What you feel internally is not obvious to listeners. Surely you will also feel as if your voice is trembling and your palms are sweaty. Again, you may be aware of these things, but they are not obvious to the audience.

Ways for Decreasing Speaking Fears

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In a true sense it is mind over matter, confidence above all, feeling that you know the subject better than anyone else, the feeling that you are in charge. If it makes you feel any better, musicians, football players, and singers have similar feelings before a performance or contest. Checklist 14.4 offers eight helpful ways to decrease your discomfort.

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING LISTENING SKILLS

Listening is a neglected study in school and colleges even though managers from around the world consider it a significant part of one's communication skills. Our review here concerns common faults of listening, purposes for listening, and results of good listening.